(ii) Organic wastes:

Organic matter such as leaves, grass, trash etc can also pollute water. Water pollution is caused by excessive phytoplankton growth within water.

Microorganisms present in water decompose these organic matter and consume dissolved oxygen in water.

Eutrophication:

Eutrophication is a process by which water bodies receive excess nutrients that stimulates excessive plant growth (algae, other plant weeds). This enhanced plant growth in water bodies is called as algae bloom.

The growth of algae in extreme abundance covers the water surface and reduces the oxygen concentration in water. Thus, bloom-infested water inhibits thegrowth of other living organisms in the water body. This process in which the nutrient rich water bodies support a dense plant population, kills animal life by depriving it of oxygen and results in loss of biodiversity is known as eutrophication.

Biochemical oxygen demand(BOD)

The total amount of oxygen in milligrams consumed by microorganisms in decomposing the waste in one litre of water at 20°C for a period of 5 days is called biochemical oxygen demand (BOD) and its value is expressed in ppm.

BOD is used as a measure of degree of water pollution. Clean water would have BOD value less than 5 ppm whereas highly polluted water has BOD value of 17 ppm or more.

Chemical Oxygen Demand (COD)

BOD measurement takes 5 days so another parameter called the Chemical Oxygen Demand (COD) is measured.

Chemical oxygen demand (COD) is defined as the amount of oxygen required by the organic matter in a sample of water for its oxidation by a strong oxidising agent like $K_2Cr_2O_7$ in acid medium for a period of 2 hrs.

(iii) Chemical wastes:

A whole variety of chemicals from industries, such as metals and solvents are poisonous to fish and other aquatic life.

Some toxic pesticides can accumulate in fish and shell fish and poison the people who eat them. Detergents and oils float and spoil the water bodies. Acids from mine drainage and salts from various sources can also contaminate water sources.

Harmful effects of chemical water pollutants:

1. Cadmium and mercury can cause kidney damage.

2. Lead poisoning can leads to the severe damage of kidneys, liver, brain etc. it also affects central nervous system

3. Polychlorinated biphenyls (PCBs) causes skin diseases and are carcinogenic in nature.

Unit 15 - jagan.indd 271 27-01-2021 15:04:19